

# Letrozole

Letrozole is a hormonal therapy drug used to treat oestrogen receptor-positive (ER-positive) breast cancer.

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## What is letrozole (Femara®)?

Letrozole is a hormonal therapy drug. It is used to treat [oestrogen receptor-positive \(ER-positive\) breast cancer](#).

It is usually used when you have been through menopause. Letrozole can also be given if you have [hormonal therapy drugs](#) to stop the ovaries working or have your ovaries removed.

Sometimes it might be used to treat breast [breast cancer in men](#), transgender (trans) women and people assigned male at birth.

You may have letrozole:

- to reduce the risk of breast cancer coming back (adjuvant treatment) – this can be before or after treatment with tamoxifen
- before surgery to try to reduce the size of the cancer
- as a first treatment if surgery is not suitable for you or needs to be delayed
- to control breast cancer that has come back or has spread to other parts of the body ([secondary breast cancer](#)).

It is best to read this information with our general information about [hormonal therapies](#) and the [type of cancer](#) you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree ([consent](#)) to have treatment. They will explain why you are having letrozole and how long you will take it for.

## More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

## How letrozole works

Letrozole reduces the amount of a type of hormone called oestrogen in the body. Hormones are chemicals that our bodies make. They act as messengers and help control how cells and organs work.

Oestrogen can encourage some breast cancers to grow. This is called [oestrogen receptor-positive \(ER-positive\) breast cancer](#). Letrozole can stop breast cancer cells from growing after menopause.

## How letrozole is given

You have letrozole as tablets you can take at home. You may have it with other hormonal therapy drugs.

During your treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

## Taking letrozole tablets

Your cancer team will discuss your treatment plan with you.

Always take the tablets exactly as they tell you to. This is important to make sure they work as well as possible for you. You take letrozole once a day with or without food.

Make sure you:

- swallow them whole with a glass of water
- do not chew, open, break or crush them
- take them at the same time every day.

If you forget to take the tablets, take the missed dose as soon as possible within the same day. If it is nearly time for the next dose (within 2 or 3 hours) the missed dose should be skipped. Do not take a double dose. Take your next dose at the usual time.

Other things to remember about your tablets:

- Keep them in the original package and at room temperature, away from moisture, heat and direct sunlight.
- Keep them safe, where children cannot see or reach them.
- If you are sick (vomit) just after taking them, do not take an extra dose. Take your next dose at the usual time.
- Get a new prescription before you run out, and make sure you have plenty for holidays.
- Do not throw away unused tablets. Return them to a pharmacy.

Your cancer team may also give you other medicines to take home. Take all your medicines exactly as they tell you to. Do not stop taking any of your medicines unless your doctor tells you to.

## About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Other cancer treatments may cause different side effects. If you are also having other cancer treatment, you may have other side effects.

When you have this treatment, you will have regular appointments with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist. Always tell them about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control most side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

Most side effects can be managed. But sometimes side effects are harder to control. It is important not to stop taking hormonal therapy without telling your doctor. If side effects cannot be managed, your doctor may suggest a different type of hormonal therapy.

## Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

## Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

## Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

### Hot flushes and sweats

Hot flushes are a common side effect of this treatment. During a flush, your neck and face may feel warm. If you have white skin, your skin may look red. If you have black or brown skin, your skin colour may deepen. Flushes can last up to 5 minutes. You might also have sweats or feel anxious or irritable during a flush.

Here are some things you can do to reduce the effects of hot flushes:

- Wear natural fabrics, such as cotton.
- Wear layers so you can remove clothes as needed.
- Use cotton sheets and layers of bedding you can remove.
- Try cooling pads or pillows to keep you cool.
- Keep rooms cool or use a fan.
- Have cold drinks and avoid caffeine and alcohol.

You might have fewer hot flushes as your body adjusts to this treatment. You could try therapies to help you [cope with hot flushes](#), such as:

- [talking therapies](#) like cognitive behaviour therapy (CBT)
- controlled breathing exercises
- yoga
- acupuncture.

If they do not improve, talk to your doctor. Certain drugs can help to improve hot flushes.

Flushes usually stop a few months after treatment ends. But some people continue to have them.

### Feeling tired (fatigue)

[Feeling tired](#) is a common side effect. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest between activities.

Being physically active can help to manage tiredness and give you more energy. It also:

- helps you sleep better
- reduces stress
- improves your bone health.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or operate machinery.

## Muscle or joint pain

You may get pain in your muscles or joints. If this happens, tell your doctor or nurse. They can give you advice and painkillers or other drugs to help. Being physically active and keeping to a healthy weight may help with the pain. It can keep your joints flexible and reduce stress on them. If the pain does not get better, tell your doctor or nurse. They may talk to you about changing to a different hormonal drug.

## Raised cholesterol level

This treatment can raise the level of cholesterol. This is a fatty substance in the blood. You may have a [blood test](#) to check the level of cholesterol. Your doctor may refer you to a dietitian for advice on diet, or prescribe medicines to control your cholesterol levels.

## Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

## Bone thinning (osteoporosis)

Taking this treatment for several months or more can increase the risk of [bone thinning](#). This is called osteoporosis. It can make you more likely to get a broken bone (fracture).

You may have bone density scans to check your bone health before and during treatment. These scans can diagnose osteoporosis or osteopenia (low bone density) so that it can be monitored. If your scan shows osteoporosis, your doctor usually prescribes:

- drugs to protect your bones called [bisphosphonates](#)
- calcium and vitamin D supplements.

Regular exercise where you support your body weight, like walking, running and dancing, can help look after your bones. This is called [weight-bearing exercise](#). Other types of strength exercises are also helpful. If you have any bone thinning or the cancer is affecting your bones, get advice from your cancer team first.

Eating a healthy diet and not smoking also helps take care of your bones.

## Feeling sick, indigestion or tummy pain

Any sickness is usually mild, but let your doctor or nurse know if this happens. Letrozole may also cause [indigestion or tummy pain](#). Tell your doctor or nurse if you have these symptoms. They can prescribe drugs to help.

## Change in appetite

You may find you lose your appetite or that your appetite increases when you are taking letrozole. If you do not have much appetite, try eating small meals often. [Eating well and keeping active](#) will help if you have concerns about your weight. If problems with eating do not get better, talk to your doctor or

nurse.

## Constipation

This treatment can cause [constipation](#). Constipation means that you are not able to pass stools (poo) as often as you normally do. It can become difficult or painful. Here are some tips that may help:

- Drink at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluids each day.
- [Eat high-fibre foods](#), such as fruit, vegetables and wholemeal bread.
- Do regular gentle exercise, like going for short walks.

If you have constipation, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number for advice. They can give you drugs called laxatives to help.

If you have not been able to pass stools for over 2 days and are being sick, contact the 24-hour number straight away.

## Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause [diarrhoea](#). Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines
- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

## Weight gain

You may gain weight when you are having this treatment. [Eating healthily and being active](#) can help you keep to a healthy weight. Your doctor, nurse or dietitian can give you more advice.

## Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

## Build-up of fluid

You may get swollen feet and ankles due to fluid building up. If you notice this or any other swelling, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist.

## Mood changes

You may feel low or depressed, or have mood swings, during this treatment. Talking to family and friends about how you feel might help. If mood changes last for more than a few weeks, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can talk to you about different ways to manage low mood or [depression](#).

## Hair thinning

While you are having this treatment, your hair may become thinner, drier and more brittle. This is usually mild. If you are worried about this, ask your nurse for advice on hair care.

## Skin changes

This treatment can [affect your skin](#). It may cause a rash, which may be itchy. Your doctor or nurse can tell you what to expect. If your skin feels dry, try using soap-free cleansers and unperfumed moisturising cream every day.

Always tell your doctor or nurse about any skin changes. They can give you advice and may prescribe creams or medicines to help. Changes to your skin usually improve when treatment ends.

## Feeling dizzy

This treatment may cause dizziness. Tell your doctor or nurse if this is a problem.

## Vaginal dryness or bleeding

This treatment can cause vaginal dryness. Non-hormonal creams, gels or lubricants can help with vaginal dryness and any discomfort during [sex](#). You can buy these from a chemist, or your doctor can prescribe them.

You might have slight vaginal bleeding for a short while:

- when you start treatment
- if you change from 1 hormonal treatment to another.

Vaginal dryness can also cause bleeding. Tell your doctor or nurse if you have any vaginal bleeding, especially if it lasts for more than a few days.

## Fast heartbeat

Some people may find their heartbeat is racing (heart palpitations) or have chest pain when taking letrozole. Speak to your GP or hospital team if you have any of these symptoms. Less commonly, letrozole may cause more serious heart problems.

Always call 999 if you have:

- chest pain
- pressure, heaviness, tightness or squeezing across the chest
- difficulty breathing.

If your symptoms are caused by this treatment, you may need steroids. You may be monitored in hospital for a time.

## **Raised blood pressure**

Tell your doctor or nurse if you have ever had any problems with your blood pressure. Your nurse will check it regularly during your treatment.

## **Dry or sore mouth and changes to taste**

This treatment can make you thirsty and your mouth dry. It can also make the lining of your mouth swollen or sore. Tell your doctor or nurse if this happens. They can suggest things to help.

You may also find that some food tastes different. Your nurse or pharmacist can give you advice.

## **Eye problems**

This treatment can cause your eyes to feel irritated. It can also cause blurry vision. Tell your doctor if you notice any problems with your eyes or eyesight.

## **Difficulty sleeping**

This treatment can affect your sleep. Tell your doctor if you are having problems. If you are feeling sleepy, do not drive or operate machinery.

## **Memory and concentration**

You may notice [changes in your memory](#). You may also find it harder to concentrate.

To help you remember things, try using:

- reminder alarms or notes on your phone
- a diary, calendar or phone app
- a notebook you carry with you.

## **Effects on the liver**

This treatment may affect how your liver works. This is usually mild and goes back to normal after treatment ends. You will have blood tests to check how well your liver is working.

## **Risk of infection**

Letrozole can reduce the number of white blood cells in your blood. These cells fight infection. If the number of white blood cells is low, you are more likely to get an infection.

If you have an infection, it is important that it is treated as soon as possible. Contact your GP if you think you have possible symptoms of infection. Signs of an infection can include:

- having a temperature over 37.5°C (99.5°F)
- feeling shaky
- a cough
- a sore throat
- needing to pass urine (pee) often.

You may have blood tests during treatment.

## Other information

### Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a [blood clot](#). Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

### Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

### Lactose

This treatment may contain lactose. If you have a lactose allergy or intolerance, ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for more information.

### Contraception

Letrozole is usually used when you have been through a natural menopause. However, if you have recently been through the menopause or are having treatment to stop your ovaries working (temporary menopause), there is still a very small chance you may become pregnant. Your doctor can tell you more about this.

If you are sexually active, it is important not to [get pregnant](#) while having this treatment. The drug may harm the developing baby.

Even if you have had your menopause, your doctor will discuss using effective contraception during your treatment.

## Fertility

This treatment is only given if you have been through menopause or are having treatment to stop your ovaries working.

If you are worried about fertility, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

## Breastfeeding

You are advised not to [breastfeed](#) while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

## Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

## About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

### References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

## The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

## How we can help

### How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

### Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



#### Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



#### Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

#### Chat online



Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to

## Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



## Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)